ENGLISH LANGUAGE • CLASSES 1 TO 5

Teaching English in Primary Classes

Young children do not learn English from rules. They learn it the way they learned Pashto and Urdu at home - by listening, copying, playing, singing and speaking a little more every day. This guide shows a primary teacher how to build that journey, step by step, in an ordinary classroom with ordinary resources.

What this guide gives you

- How children aged 5 to 11 actually learn a new language
- Listening and speaking first - the foundation for Classes 1 to 3
- Phonics, early reading and vocabulary without rote cramming
- Writing in stages, games and songs, and a 35-minute lesson plan
- Gentle assessment and a weekly checklist you can use from Monday

The golden rule of primary English

Understand first, speak second, read third, write last. If a child can understand and say a sentence, reading and writing that same sentence becomes easy. If we reverse the order - copy first, understand never - English becomes a subject to fear. Every method in this guide follows the natural order: **Listen → Speak → Read → Write.**

> **For the teacher:** You do not need perfect English to teach primary English well. You need clear pronunciation of the words you teach, short correct sentences, a warm manner, and consistency. Children copy your confidence more than your accent.

Prepared for primary school teachers in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. Aligned with the Single National Curriculum early grades and the pedagogy covered in the Induction Programme for Primary School Teachers.

Children learn a language by using it, not by studying it

A five-year-old learns hundreds of words in her mother tongue without a single grammar lesson. She listens, watches faces and hands, guesses, tries, makes mistakes and is gently corrected. English in school should borrow the same path - with the teacher creating the listening, guessing and trying inside the classroom.

Five facts about young language learners

1. **They learn through the senses.** A word sticks when a child hears it, sees the object or picture, touches or points to it, and says it. Teach *apple* with a real apple or a clear picture - never with translation alone.
2. **They imitate before they understand fully.** Choral repetition, rhymes and classroom routines ("Stand up", "Open your books") build pronunciation and courage.
3. **Their attention is short.** Change activity every 5 to 8 minutes in Classes 1 to 2, every 8 to 12 minutes in Classes 4 to 5. One long explanation loses the whole class.
4. **They are not afraid of mistakes - until we make them afraid.** Praise the attempt first. A child who is laughed at for a wrong answer will stay silent for months.
5. **They learn in chunks.** Teach whole useful phrases - ***"Good morning", "May I come in?", "I like mangoes"*** - before breaking them into grammar parts.

What this means in each class band

Classes	Main goal	Main method
1 - 2	Listening, speaking, letter sounds, joy in English	Songs, actions, pictures, oral games, tracing
3	Reading simple text, writing words and short sentences	Phonics blending, shared reading, guided writing
4 - 5	Reading with understanding, paragraphs, conversation	Silent reading, pair talk, free writing, presentations

> **Remember:** Translation has a small place - one Pashto or Urdu word to unlock meaning quickly is fine. But if every English sentence is translated, children wait for the translation and stop listening to English itself.

Listening and speaking come first

For the first two years, your English period should sound like English. Children need to hear the language every day - in greetings, instructions, stories and songs - before anyone asks them to read a paragraph or write a dictation.

Build an English routine (5 minutes, every day)

Use the same English for the same moments daily. Within weeks, even shy children respond without thinking:

> ***"Good morning, class." - "Assalam-o-Alaikum, sit down, please." - "How are you today?" - "Open your English copy." - "Listen carefully." - "Very good. Clap for her."***

Listening activities that need nothing but your voice

- **Listen and do:** Give instructions - "Touch your nose. Stand up. Point to the door." Children act, you see who understood.
- **Listen and point:** Say a word; children point to the picture, object or flashcard.
- **Story listening:** Tell a 3-minute story with voice changes and gestures. Ask two easy questions at the end.
- **Odd one out:** Say "cat, dog, hen, table" - children clap when they hear the word that does not belong.

Speaking: from one word to full sentences

Stage	Child says	Teacher does
1. Word	"Ball."	Accept, smile, expand: "Yes, a red ball."
2. Phrase	"Red ball."	Model the full form: "It is a red ball."
3. Sentence	"It is a red ball."	Extend: "Yes! It is a big, red ball."
4. Exchange	Asks and answers with a partner	Set pair dialogues, walk, listen, praise

Correcting speech: never interrupt to fix grammar mid-sentence. Repeat the child's meaning back correctly - this is called recasting. Child: "He go to school." Teacher: "Yes, he *goes* to school every day." The lesson lands without shame.

> **Talk time rule:** In a good primary English lesson, children speak more than the teacher. Aim for choral work, pair work and group answers in every period - not only the front row answering alone.

Sounds first, then reading with meaning

English reading fails when children memorise whole words as pictures. It succeeds when they learn the sounds of letters and blend them. A child who can blend *c-a-t* can attack hundreds of new words alone.

Phonics in the right order

1. **Letter sounds, not letter names first:** Teach "sss" for S and "mmm" for M before the ABC song names. Names come alongside, sounds do the reading work.
2. **Blend short words early:** Once 6 to 8 sounds are known, blend: *at, in, am, sat, pin, man*. Celebrate every successful blend.
3. **Word families:** Teach *-at* (cat, bat, hat, mat), *-in*, *-op* together. Patterns are easier than single words.
4. **Sight words separately:** Common words that do not follow sounds - *the, is, are, was, my* - are learned by sight with flashcards and repeated reading.

Reading aloud and shared reading

- Read a short text aloud while children follow with a finger. Your voice teaches pronunciation, pauses and expression.
- Ask meaning questions, not only word reading: "Who is in the story? What happened first? What will happen next?"
- Let children read in pairs - one reads, one listens and helps - then change roles.
- Keep a small class library corner: even 15 storybooks, rotated weekly, change reading habits.

Vocabulary: teach words in families and in use

Teach in themes
Body, family, school objects, colours, animals, food, weather, actions. 5 to 7 new words per lesson is enough - more is forgotten.

Teach in a sentence
Not "hungry = bhooka" alone, but "I am hungry. Are you hungry?" The sentence carries the word into real use.

Revision is the secret: a word taught once is lost. Recycle old words in warm-ups, games and dictations for at least two weeks. Keep a word wall or a corner of the board where this month's words stay visible.

Writing grows in stages - never punish the early ones

Stage	What it looks like	Classes
1. Readiness	Lines, curves, patterns, tracing letters in air, sand and on paper	1
2. Copying	Letters, words and sentences copied neatly from the board	1 - 2
3. Guided writing	Fill the gap, complete the sentence, write from a word bank	2 - 4
4. Free writing	Own sentences and a short paragraph about a picture or topic	4 - 5

Check *one thing at a time* when marking: this week capital letters, next week full stops. Marking every spelling, grammar and handwriting error in red teaches only one lesson - writing is dangerous. Praise what is correct first, in words, on the page.

A 35-minute English lesson that works

Minutes	Stage	What happens
0 - 5	**Warm-up**	Greeting routine, one song or rhyme, quick revision game of old words
5 - 12	**Presentation**	New words or text introduced with pictures, actions and examples
12 - 22	**Practice**	Choral, pair and group work; reading together; short oral drills
22 - 31	**Production**	Children use the language themselves: dialogues, writing, a mini task
31 - 35	**Wrap-up**	Quick oral check of 3 to 4 children, praise, one-line homework

Sample lesson - Class 3, "My School Bag": Warm-up with the colours song. Present *book, copy, pencil, bag, ruler* from a real bag. Practice: "What is this?" in pairs with real objects. Production: each child says two sentences - "This is my book. It is blue." Wrap-up: hold up objects, class answers together.

Board work: Date and topic on the left, new words with a small drawing or example on the right, children's work in the middle. A tidy board is a free textbook for a child who missed a day.

Ten games and songs that teach while children play

1. **Simon Says** - listening and action verbs. Only obey when "Simon says" comes first.
2. **Flashcard race** - two children run to touch the card you name. Vocabulary speed and joy.
3. **Word chain** - each child says a word starting with the last letter of the previous word.
4. **Hot seat** - one child sits with a picture on the forehead; the class gives clues in English.
5. **Pass the ball** - music or clapping stops, the child holding the ball answers a question.
6. **Rhymes with actions** - "Head, shoulders, knees and toes" teaches body words forever.
7. **Picture talk** - show any picture; pairs make three sentences about it.
8. **Dictation pairs** - one reads a sentence, the other writes; then compare with the book.
9. **Categories clap** - clap only for animal words, fruit words, action words - as you call a mixed list.
10. **Show and tell** - Friday: a child brings one object and speaks three sentences about it.

Assessment without fear

At primary level, assessment is mostly **watching and listening**: Can the child follow instructions? Answer in a sentence? Read a short paragraph and tell what it means? Keep a simple notebook record per child - date, skill checked, one short note. Add one short written check per month. Never rank young children publicly by English marks; report progress to parents in plain words - what the child can do now, and what comes next.

Teacher's weekly checklist

☐ Every lesson started with speaking, not silent copying

☐ New words taught with a picture, object or action - and used in sentences

☐ Old words revised at least twice this week

☐ Every child spoke English aloud at least once each day

☐ One story, rhyme or song used this week

☐ Writing checked for one focus only - and praised before corrected

☐ Quiet and shy children invited gently, never forced or mocked

End of notes. Companion guides in this series cover classroom arrangement, child psychology, pedagogy, mathematics, ICT in primary schools and other induction topics - each as its own separate PDF.